

Plurals

A A plural noun is a noun that refers to more than one person, place, thing, or idea. Most singular nouns are made plural by adding a suffix **-s**:

- equation → equations
- code → codes

The ending **-es** is added if a word ends in **-s, -ss, -sh, -ch, -tch** or **-x**:

- address → addresses
- virus → viruses

The ending **-es** is also added if a word ends in a consonant +*y*; the *y* becomes *i* before the ending **-es**.

- equality → equalities
- theory → theories

However, if *y* follows a vowel, we add only **-s**.

- gameplay → gameplays
- key → keys

B There are certain interesting exceptions to this rule, many of which are scientific or technical terms that have come into English from other languages like Latin and Greek, and keep the plural form of the language from which they have been borrowed. For instance, the plural of *radius* can be either *radii* (from the Latin plural) or the conventional English plural *radiuses*. Also,

analysis → analyses	maximum → maximums (or maxima)
axis → axes	minimum → minimums (or minima)
criterion → criteria	modulus → moduli
formula → formulas (or formulae)	(computer) mouse → mouses (or mice)
hypothesis → hypotheses	parenthesis → parentheses
index → indices (or indexes)	radix → radices (or radices)
locus → loci	series → series
matrix → matrices (or matrixes)	vertex → vertices (or vertexes)

C Uncountable and mass nouns (*e.g.*, **information, knowledge, equipment**) do not have a plural form:

- My **knowledge** (not ~~knowledges~~) of JavaScript *is* very limited.

Some nouns, like **data** (*sg.* datum) and **media** (*sg.* medium), that were originally plural are now often used as uncountable nouns with a singular verb:

- Now the **data** *is* being transferred from the cloud to the hard disk.
- New **media** *has led* to cultural globalization.

D Some nouns that end in **-ics**, like **mathematics (=maths), electronics, informatics, graphics, analytics, robotics, biometrics** are not usually plural and take a singular verb:

- **Mathematics** *is* the science and study of quality, structure, space, and change.

E Collective nouns, like **team, class, group, security, personnel, staff**, take a singular verb when the entity acts together and a plural verb when the individuals composing the entity act individually:

- Our **team** *is/are* not happy with the new project manager.

We think of a sum of money, a period of time, a distance, etc. as one thing. So, we use a singular verb.

■ Three weeks *is* enough time to fix bugs in this application.